CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

TROUBLE IN THE TEA GARDENS

Strife in Serenity

Not many would have expected the serene and tranquil tea gardens of Assam to add to Ratan's challenges after he became chairman, Tata Sons. But the tea gardens had become a hotbed for terrorist activities. It was the first time Ratan was thrown into the midst of a political maelstrom. For a man who had waged corporate battles effectively, this was an unfamiliar ring where he had to find his feet.

The Tatas weren't part of the food industry until the beginning of the 1960s, when James Finlay & Co., a Scotland-based tea plantation company, decided to scale down its operations in India. Sensing an attractive business opportunity, the Tatas entered a JV with the Scottish company in October 1962. Two decades later, in 1983, James Finlay sold its shareholding to them, giving birth to Tata Tea. With over twenty-one estates, the new company emerged as the largest producer of tea in the country with the largest holdings in Assam.

As Tata Tea expanded its footprint, it did not realize that it was wading into troubled waters. By the end of the 1970s, Assam's local populace was restless. Their identity was threatened by the growing population of migrants. Though the problem was not new, it took a more serious turn with the influx of refugees to the state after the creation of the nation of Bangladesh in 1971. The locals complained of neglect and discrimination. Some sections even called for secession from India as the only way to protect their identity.

The discontentment grew worse, leading to a mass movement spearheaded by the All-Assam Students' Union (AASU), demanding the deportation of illegal immigrants. Another body called the United